However, the tipping point came two weeks later at a news conference, when Russian Federation President Boris Yeltsin was asked to expand on the question of Honecker and the issue of Russian-German relations.

Our position on Honecker remains as it was. He is with the Chileans at the moment. Let Mr. Kohl decide this issue, together with the Chilean leadership. We do not intend to keep him in our country. We intend to hand him over to Germany. They can deal with him according to justice and according to the law in whatever way they feel necessary. It is all a matter for them. But we will not permit him to live illegally on our territory.

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Yeltsin's comments were enough for Santiago to draft an official revocation of Honecker's guest status. 'It was a police operation,' Holger recounted, giving a vivid snapshot of events. 'The [Russian] Undersecretary of Justice told me: "You put Honecker at the embassy door. Then the KGB will take him and escort him to a military plane."' 37

The absurdity came to a head after Aylwin gave the go-ahead for the eviction on the evening of 28 July. The following afternoon, Holger, acting without preamble, thrust the typewritten revocation paper into Honecker's hand. The measure of surprise had its effect. After a surly outburst and minilecture, the former General Secretary scrawled: 'acknowledged under protest' on the bottom corner of the paper.38

From here on, events moved at lightning speed. With four uniformed Russian security officials looking on, the former General Secretary was given ten minutes to pack and present himself at the front door. Holger reflected: